

The 6-Figure Squeeze No One Warned You About

You got the raise. The bonus landed. The title finally matched the workload. On paper, you are winning.

So why does it still feel like you are one bad month away from trouble?

You are not imagining it, and you are not bad with money. Researchers are now naming this exact feeling. A recent Gallup study conducted for Edward Jones found that nearly seven in ten Americans earning more than \$135,000 a year do not feel financially fulfilled, and 77% of those earning between \$135,000 and \$175,000 say they are dissatisfied with their financial situation, even as their income climbs ([Fortune](#)). One in five high earners in that study said they feel depressed just thinking about their money. The researchers call it money dysmorphia: a gap between how your finances actually look and how they feel.

The number crunchers at Goldman Sachs found the same pattern. In their 2025 research, 41% of households earning between \$300,000 and \$500,000 said they live paycheck to paycheck, and 40% of households earning over \$500,000 did too ([Fortune](#)). Consulting firm Kearney has started calling this group the ones "on thin ice": high earners who look secure from the outside but are one job change, one market dip, or one renewal notice away from real strain ([Fortune](#)).

Here in Calgary, add a Canadian layer to the pressure. The Bank of Canada estimates that about 60% of mortgage holders renewing in 2025 and 2026 will see their payment go up, with the average payment running roughly 10% higher than in December 2024 ([Bank of Canada](#)). A Royal LePage survey from August 2026 found that one in three renewing homeowners feel more anxious than they did at their last renewal ([Wealth Professional](#)). Bonus season, mortgage renewal, and daycare invoices all landing in the same quarter is not a coincidence. It is the new normal for many high-earning households.

Think about a farm during a good year. The harvest is strong, the barn is full, and everything looks abundant. But abundance does not manage itself. Weeds grow just as fast in a good season as in a bad one. Left alone, they choke out the crop meant to feed the family through winter.

Lifestyle creep is the weeds. Every raise, every bonus, every good year quietly invites a bigger house, a nicer car, one more subscription, one more upgrade that felt earned in the moment. None of it is reckless. It just adds up until there is nothing left over to plant for next season. That is exactly what the Fortune and Kearney research above describes: income going up while the room to breathe goes down.

The fix is not to stop enjoying the harvest. It is to build irrigation. A working farm does not water itself by hand every day and hope for rain. It builds systems, pipes, timers, and rules so water reaches the right rows automatically, even during a drought. Your finances need the same kind of system: automated savings, a clear cash flow map, and rules for what happens to a bonus before it hits your account and starts feeling like spending money.

You plant now so you can harvest later. That means putting money to work while your income is high, not waiting for a mythical moment when things finally feel settled. High earners who wait for "settled" often wait past the years when their income had the most power to compound.

Here is the real problem, and it is not the market, the mortgage renewal, or the bonus structure. It is the quiet lie that "you're fine."

You make good money. You save a bit. You invest a bit. You're fine.

Except "fine" is how people reach their fifties, still needing every paycheck and wondering if they made the most of the years when their income was highest. Being fine is the status quo, and the status quo is not a plan. It is the absence of one.

You are already working fifty or sixty hours a week. Your money should not become a second job. That is the whole case for delegation. A fiduciary does not sell you a product and move on. A fiduciary looks at your whole farm, income, debt, spending, savings, and goals, in plain English, and builds a system that runs whether or not you have time to think about it that week.

At Red Barn, we are a registered Portfolio Manager, which means we have a fiduciary duty to act in your best interest. We charge a transparent advisory fee based on assets under management. We do not receive commissions or trailer fees from product manufacturers, so there is no incentive to sell you something you do not need. The goal is not to make you "fine." It is to make your money work better, serving the life you are actually building, not around products and buzzwords.

Past performance is not an indicator of future performance.

Book your Clarity Plan intro call.

Thirty minutes, zero fluff. You will walk away with a clearer picture of where you stand and what a plan built around your actual life could look like, not a sales pitch.

Link: [Book an intro call](#)

Download the free guide.

If you are not ready for a call yet, start with "When Doing Well Still Feels Fragile," a short, plain-English guide built for people who make good money and still feel the squeeze.

Link: [Read the guide](#)

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